INTERVIEW THESIS BRIEF

Russell Dudek

DIGITAL INNOVATION & ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE LEADER

Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania 412.287.8640 russelldudek@gmail.com linkedin.com/in/russelldudek Google Scholar https://russelldudek.github.io/Vontier/

Make distributed innovation behave like one enterprise capability.

The mandate behind the job description

Vontier needs a leader who can connect outside-in innovation, customer problems, business-unit ideas, industrial technology, AI engineering, and VBS discipline - then move the best work into production across a global portfolio.

Why now

Enterprise innovation, AI strategy, and digital modernization have been placed under a new Chief Innovation and Growth Officer. The role is a build mandate, not a maintenance position.

Why this is hard

The portfolio contains radically different products, installed bases, data environments, customer risks, and local economics. A centralized lab can become irrelevant; pure decentralization creates duplication and weak reuse.

Thesis

Vontier should centralize the evidence and deployment contract - not the customer problem. Business units own the problem and outcome. The enterprise makes the work easier to prove, secure, deploy, monitor, adopt, and reuse.

OPERATING TENSIONS

Four contradictions the role must manage.

Autonomy / common leverage

Protect local customer judgment while creating enterprise patterns, shared guardrails, and transparent investment choices.

Pilot speed / production truth

Move quickly without hiding data quality, ownership, security, validation, monitoring, support, or adoption requirements until late.

Cloud intelligence / edge reality

Design for devices, PLCs, sensors, payments, bandwidth, safety, technicians, installed-base constraints, and cyber boundaries.

Outside-in / VBS discipline

Absorb ecosystem advances without replacing kaizen, operating ownership, and measurable outcomes with vendor-led novelty.

Decision architecture

Decision	Enterprise role	Business-unit role
What enters the portfolio?	Common idea brief and comparison logic	Customer problem, user, economics, local urgency
What gets funded?	Evidence thresholds and portfolio balance	Outcome ownership and resource commitment
What gets standardized?	Architecture, controls, evaluation, MLOps, reusable assets	Workflow implementation and legitimate local variants
What gets stopped?	Transparent stop/hold criteria	Accept and act on evidence without political penalty

OPERATING MODEL

The Innovation Torque Converter

Open

Harvest without commitment. Make the problem, decision, user, economics, data reality, risk, and strategic fit visible before selecting technology.

Coupling

Run controlled experiments with explicit evidence, human authority, ownership, deployment assumptions, and a stop condition.

Lock-up

Move proven work into production with reusable architecture, MLOps, security, validation, monitoring, adoption, and economics.

Learning return

Return playbooks, taxonomies, components, evaluations, vendor knowledge, and failure evidence to every relevant business unit.

Portfolio review

State	Required evidence	Legitimate decision
Open	Problem quality, user, decision, strategic relevance, plausible data	Explore / clarify / decline
Coupling	Baseline, test, authority, owner, architecture assumption, adoption path	Continue / revise / hold / stop
Lock-up	Production plan, controls, MLOps, support, economics, adoption proof	Deploy / standardize / scale
Learning return	Reusable asset and explicit transfer owner	Publish / teach / integrate / retire

EVIDENCE MAP

Why Russell's evidence transfers.

Vape-Jet

Current hands-on operating transformation across robotics, machine vision, ERP, quality, support, customer success, telemetry, engineering issue flow, and AI-assisted workflows.

DudeWorth

Direct design of AI readiness, opportunity, agentic workflow, retrieval, human-review, evaluation, and governance mechanisms.

Compunetics

Advanced electronics, manufacturing, quality, high-reliability customers, technical programs, talks, and industry consortium participation.

Amazon

24/7 launch and operating mechanisms at scale; Lean/Gemba; throughput, quality, safety, customer experience, and escalation discipline.

ZeusVu

Regulated autonomous systems, TensorFlow-based computer-vision concepts, safety, chain of custody, and stakeholder coordination.

Science + sustainability

Materials science and physical chemistry grounding; public Google Scholar profile; sustainable infrastructure and green-finance experience.

Affirmative leadership advantage

Russell's advantage is the combination: he can talk to engineers about architecture and controls, operators about standard work and exceptions, executives about portfolio value, customers about outcomes, and teams about adoption - while still working directly in the workflow and evidence.

ENTRY PLAN

Earn the right to standardize.

0-30: Read

- Executive and BU problem interviews
- Active use-case and pilot inventory
- IT/OT, data, cyber, MLOps and vendor map
- Adoption and decision-rights diagnosis

31-60: Contract

- Idea brief and portfolio taxonomy
- Evidence and human-authority requirements
- Reusable architecture patterns
- Review cadence and stop/scale logic

61-90: Prove

- Operational workflow pilot
- Customer-facing pilot
- Edge/industrial pilot
- Instrument value, trust and adoption

91-120: Compound

- Move strongest proof toward production
- Publish reusable assets and lessons
- Launch virtual expert network
- Present transparent portfolio decisions

Measures

Outcome improvement; time from signal to decision; pilot-to-production conversion; time to stop weak work; reuse across business units; production reliability; adoption behavior; auditability; vendor leverage; and learning returned to the portfolio.

EXECUTIVE DIALOGUE

Questions and interview lines.

Five executive questions

1. Where does Vontier currently lose the most energy between a strong innovation idea and a scaled outcome?
2. Which decisions should remain local to business units, and which should become enterprise contracts?
3. What would make the first year unquestionably valuable to customers and business-unit presidents?
4. How should VBS change the way AI pilots are selected, reviewed, stopped, and reused?
5. Where do payments, connected devices, field service, and industrial controls create a unique data or trust advantage?

Opening line

"I see this as a transmission problem more than an idea problem: how do we preserve local speed while making evidence, architecture, governance, adoption, and learning transferable across Vontier?"

Closing line

"I would not centralize innovation. I would centralize the contracts that make innovation easier to trust, deploy, and reuse."

Public source basis

Vontier 2025 Form 10-K; Vontier corporate strategy and portfolio pages; Vontier appointment announcement for the Chief Innovation and Growth Officer; public job description supplied with this campaign. Interpretations are labeled as candidate hypotheses.